



A More Perfect Realm

*A Curated Modlist & Beginner's Tutorial
for Crusader Kings 3 (2026)*

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Learning Crusader Kings 3 (2026)

What is CK3?

Crusader Kings 3 is a grand strategy role-playing game set in the Middle Ages (867–1453). Unlike traditional strategy games where you control a nation, in CK3 you control a **dynasty** through the generations. You play as a character — you live, scheme, marry, fight, and die. Then you play as your heir.

The map covers Europe, North Africa, the Middle East, India, and Central Asia. Every province, every ruler, every courtier is simulated. The game generates stories: betrayal, romance, war, plague, triumph. With the 2026 DLC, the game includes expanded travel mechanics, plagues, tournaments, regency, and more.

The core question CK3 asks is not “how do I conquer the world?” but “what kind of ruler will I be?”

Choosing Your First Ruler

For your first game, pick a small, stable ruler where you can learn the mechanics without being crushed:

Recommended First Stops

- **Dublin (1066, Ireland):** Independent Petty King under no liege. No aggressive neighbors (the Irish are similarly weak). Learn at your own pace and form the Kingdom of Ireland. This is **the** tutorial start.
- **Matilda di Canossa (1066, Tuscany):** Powerful Italian duke under the Holy Roman Empire. Strong economy, central Italy, good marriage options. You must navigate imperial politics but have enough power to matter.
- **Count of Vermandois (1066, France):** Small French count protected by France. Dynasty prestige from being Karlings. Simple domain, strong liege, safe learning environment.

Starts to Avoid

- **Byzantine Empire:** Too complex. Intrigue is lethal, vassals are treacherous, mechanics are overwhelming.
- **Tribal rulers (867 anywhere):** Different economy (prestige-based, not gold). Raiding, prestige deaths, succession chaos.
- **Muslim rulers:** Different succession (multiple heirs, no primogeniture), different faith mechanics.
- **867 Viking starts:** Everyone hates you, raids go both ways, and your first decade is war.

The Interface

The CK3 interface has three layers you need to understand immediately:

Map modes (F1–F12): F1 (terrain), F2 (de jure kingdoms/empires), F3 (culture), F4 (faith), F5 (development), F7 (alliances). You'll spend 90% of your time in F2 (de jure) and normal map view.

The left panel: Your character portrait (top) with stats, traits, health. Below: your council (chancellor, marshal, steward, spymaster, chaplain), your court (visitors, prisoners), and your courtiers.

The right panel: Decisions, notifications, alerts. The top bar shows gold, prestige, piety, renown. The bottom bar has the outliner — every holding, army, scheme, and character you care about in one list.

The character finder (C): The most important tool in the game. Find marriage candidates, councilors, knights, and courtiers by any filter imaginable.

Core Loop

CK3's gameplay loop is a circle:

1. **Scheme** — Pick a goal (get a claim, marry an heiress, murder a rival)
2. **Prepare** — Save gold, sway necessary people, build alliances
3. **Act** — Press your claim, propose marriage, execute the murder
4. **Consolidate** — Manage your new territory, deal with fallout, stabilize
5. **Grow** — Build buildings, develop your domain, increase your dynasty
6. **Repeat** — Your ruler ages. Scheme for your heir's future even as you play your current ruler

This loop works at every scale: a count schemes for a county, a duke for a kingdom, an emperor for an empire.

Setting Goals

CK3 is a sandbox. You need your own goals or you'll drift aimlessly:

Goal Type	Examples
Conquest	Form the Kingdom of Ireland. Restore the Roman Empire. Reclaim Alexander's borders.
Dynasty	Get 10,000 renown. Put your dynasty on 5 thrones. Breed the Perfect Heir (Genius + Beautiful + Herculean).
Roleplay	Create a witch coven. Become a legendary reveler. Convert all of Europe to a heresy.
Challenge	Start as a one-county count and become emperor. Achieve world peace (no wars). Play tall (three counties max development).
Achievement	Pick an in-game achievement and build your campaign around it.

Write down your goal. The game is more rewarding when you have direction.

Marriage & Land

Deep dive: How to use marriage to expand your realm.

The Three Uses of Marriage

Marriage in CK3 serves three distinct purposes:

1. **Alliances** — Your spouse's family becomes your ally. A well-married daughter can bring a kingdom into your wars.
2. **Claims** — Your spouse's claims can become your children's claims. Your children's claims can become **your** wars.
3. **Genetics** — Congenital traits (Intelligent, Beautiful, Herculean, Fecund) stack across generations. Breed for them.

Matrilineal Marriage – When and Why

A matrilineal marriage means children belong to the **mother's** dynasty, not the father's. Use it when:

- You have only daughters and no sons (your dynasty dies otherwise)
- You want to bring a talented character into your court without losing your dynasty name
- You want to inherit land: marry your daughter matrilineally to a second son of a kingdom. Their children (your grandchildren) will have claims on that kingdom. **Then you press those claims for your dynasty.**

Remember: AI rulers rarely accept matrilineal marriage for their primary heir. Target second, third, or fourth sons.

Claiming Land Through Marriage

This is the most powerful (and most overlooked) expansion mechanic:

1. Find a character with a claim on a title you want (character finder > filter: has claims)
2. Marry them into your dynasty (matrilineally if needed)
3. Have children with them
4. Your child inherits the claim
5. Press your child's claim in war
6. Your dynasty member now rules that title — as your ally

For pressing **spouse** claims directly: your spouse must be your faith, their claim must be inheritable, and you must be willing to go to war for it.

Murder as an Inheritance Tool

If the person standing between your dynasty and a title is inconvenient: murder them. Each murder in the succession line moves your target closer to inheritance. Be careful — getting caught as a known murderer destroys your reputation and makes everyone hate you.

Breeding for Traits

Congenital traits (level 1 traits like Quick, level 2 like Intelligent, level 3 like Genius) stack:

- Two parents with the same tier trait = high chance child inherits it
- Two parents with different tier traits = chance child inherits the highest tier
- Blood legacy perks increase inheritance chance
- Inbreeding increases trait inheritance but also increases negative traits (inbred trait)

The Perfect Heir build: marry Genius characters, use the Blood dynasty legacy, and over generations your dynasty becomes superhuman.

Succession & Dynasties

Deep dive: Keeping your realm together when your ruler dies.

Succession Types

Your realm splinters on death based on succession law. Understanding this is critical:

- **Confederate Partition (default):** All sons inherit equally. New titles are **automatically created** if you hold enough land to form them. This means your kingdom might split into multiple kingdoms on death.
- **Partition:** Same as Confederate, but new titles are NOT automatically created. Still splits your realm.
- **High Partition:** Your primary heir gets the majority. Secondary heirs get a smaller share.
- **Primogeniture:** Everything goes to your firstborn. Requires high crown authority and late medieval era.
- **Elective:** Various forms (Feudal, Saxon, Tanistry, Princely). Your vassals vote on the heir. You can manipulate votes but cannot fully control them.

Managing Partition

Until you get Primogeniture (usually 200+ years in), Partition is your reality. Strategies:

- **Disinherit:** Costs 150 renown per child. Expensive but reliable. Disinherit all but your best heir.
- **Force vows:** Send excess sons to the clergy (if your faith allows). They can't inherit.
- **Kill excess sons:** Imprison and execute. Extremely tyrannical but effective. Everyone will hate you.
- **Grant titles before death:** Give secondary sons land **before** you die. They inherit their granted land but don't partition your core domain.
- **Conquer enough for everyone:** If you hold two kingdom titles, your secondary son becomes king of the second kingdom instead of splitting your primary.
- **Designate heir (Absolute Crown Authority):** At absolute crown authority, you can pick any child as heir. Expensive and requires late tech.

Dynasty Mechanics

Your dynasty is your real identity. Key concepts:

- **Renown:** Generated by living dynasty members (especially rulers). Spent on dynasty legacies (permanent bonuses).
- **Legacies:** Blood (traits), Guile (intrigue), Kin (family), Glory (war), Law (stewardship). Blood is the most popular first tree.
- **Cadet branches:** When a dynasty member becomes powerful enough, they can form a cadet branch. Independent cadet branches generate renown for the main dynasty.
- **Dynasty head:** The most powerful member of the dynasty by realm size. Can legitimize bastards, disinherit, and call dynasty members to war.

House Unity

With the latest DLC, house unity affects realm stability. Keep your house members happy through grants, marriages, and sway schemes. Low house unity means more factions, more murder plots, and less tax income from dynasty members.

Religion

Deep dive: Faith as a weapon.

Faith Mechanics

Your faith determines:

- What's considered criminal (adultery, witchcraft, sodomy)
- Who can hold religious office (gender equality)
- How the afterlife works (and who goes where)
- Holy sites: control them for bonuses
- Head of Faith: the Pope, Caliph, or Ecumenical Patriarch can grant claims, excommunicate, and call holy wars

Creating a New Faith

The most powerful mid-game move: create your own faith.

Why do it:

- Make your ruler the Head of Faith (you get all that Pope money)
- Remove unpopular doctrines (no more “crime” for homosexuality)
- Add popular doctrines (Communion = money from followers, Armed Pilgrimages = free CBs)
- Make women equal (more council options)
- Make witchcraft accepted (more schemes)

How to do it:

1. Accumulate piety (pilgrimages, building churches, holy wars)
2. Open the faith tab > Create New Faith
3. Choose your tenets, doctrines, and Head of Faith status
4. Your new faith is a **heresy** of the old one — expect holy wars from your former co-religionists

Strategic tips:

- Keep some core tenets the same to reduce opinion penalties
- Make your capital the new Head of Faith title
- Add Pastoral Isolation (reduces conversion pressure from other faiths)
- Be prepared for a massive opinion hit from your former faith

Holy Wars

Different CBs unlock at different fervor levels:

- **Sanctioned invasions:** A ruler is evil and you want their whole kingdom
- **Great Holy Wars:** Called by the Head of Faith. Everyone joins. Massive war.
- **Crusades/Jihads:** The big ones. Win to place a dynasty member on a kingdom throne.

Low fervor in your faith means fewer holy wars. High fervor means more. Heresies reduce fervor significantly.

Culture

Cultural Pillars: Heritage, Language, Aesthetics, Martial Custom. These barely change during a campaign.

Traditions: The active mechanics. Each culture has 3–5 traditions. You can add/remove traditions with enough prestige and cultural acceptance.

Diverging vs Hybridizing:

- **Diverge:** Split your culture into a new one. Useful if you've migrated somewhere new.
- **Hybridize:** Merge two cultures. Get traditions from both. Best way to get powerful combinations.

Innovations: Culture advances through eras (Tribal > Early Medieval > High Medieval > Late Medieval). Shared between same-culture rulers. Being ahead on innovations gives you better MaA, buildings, and laws.

Warfare

MaA (Men-at-Arms): Your professional army. Culture-specific units are usually stronger. Build counter-MaA against your neighbor's composition (Spearmen beat Cavalry, Pikemen beat heavy infantry, etc.).

Knights: Each knight is a character. High prowess = valuable knight. Low prowess = dead knight. Equipment (from artifacts) increases prowess.

Supply: Armies need supply. Marching 10,000 men through the Sahara = attrition disaster. Plan routes through friendly or high-supply territory.

Sieges: You don't need to fight every battle. Siege weapons (trebuchets, siege towers) reduce siege time. Siege down holdings to win wars faster than fighting field battles.

Mercenaries & Holy Orders: Expensive but effective. Holy Orders cheaper if you share their faith. Contract them for specific wars, dismiss when done.

Declaring war effectively:

- Check alliance chains first (are they allied to France?)
- Declare when your MaA are fully reinforced
- Have a CB (Casus Belli) — press claim, holy war, conquest
- Call your allies before declaring

Vassal Management

Deep dive: Keeping your realm from tearing itself apart.

The Vassal Problem

Your vassals want four things:

1. More land (they covet your titles)
2. More power (they want council positions, lower obligations)
3. Their culture/faith respected (wrong culture/faith = -40 opinion)
4. Your throne (factions)

Ignore any of these and factions will fire.

Factions

The five major factions:

- **Liberty Faction:** Wants lower crown authority or council rights
- **Independence Faction:** Wants to leave your realm
- **Claimant Faction:** Wants someone else on your throne
- **Tax Faction:** Wants lower tax obligations
- **Cultural Faction:** Wrong-culture vassals organizing

Managing factions:

- **Prevention:** Keep vassal opinion above 0. Sway, grant artifacts, send gifts, host feasts.
- **Dread:** Execute prisoners. High dread keeps factions from forming (vassals are too scared).
- **Alliances:** Marry your children to powerful vassals' children. They can't faction against family.
- **Tit-for-tat:** When a faction fires, check its members. Can you kill the leader? Imprison them? Ally with the leader?
- **Concessions:** Sometimes giving in (lower crown authority temporarily) is better than civil war.

Hooks

Hooks are **leverage** over a character. Use them to:

- Force vassals to accept higher obligations
- Force vassals to vote your way
- Prevent vassals from joining factions
- Get council position acceptance

Gain hooks through: fabricate hook scheme, secrets (expose or blackmail), swaying powerful vassals, the Spymaster's find secrets task.

Crown Authority

Each crown authority level changes vassal dynamics:

- **Level 1:** Vassals can war each other. You can't revoke titles without tyranny.
- **Level 2:** You can revoke criminal titles. Vassals can't war each other.
- **Level 3:** You can designate heir (with Absolute). Vassal contracts matter more.

- **Level 4 (Absolute):** Designate any heir. No vassal war declarations at all.

Higher authority = more stability, lower vassal opinion. Balance accordingly.

Council Rights

The council can have varying power:

- **No council rights:** You control everything. Low vassal happiness.
- **Council voting on war:** You need council approval to declare war. Frustrating.
- **Council voting on everything:** Very stable but very slow.

Grant council rights to powerful vassals who want them. Take them back when you're strong enough to handle the rebellion.

The Dread Tax

Dread is temporary fear. When you execute prisoners, you gain dread. Dread decays over time.

High dread:

- Prevents factions from forming
- Speeds up scheme detection against you
- Makes vassals less likely to refuse demands

But: high dread also makes **everyone** hate you personally. Your vassals won't rebel, but they won't help you either. Use dread as a tool, not a lifestyle.

The Endgame

Once you're an emperor with stabilized succession, the game changes:

Managing a sprawling empire: Delegate. Give kingdoms to dynasty members. Set up stable vassal kings who like you. Use theocratic vassals (bishops) for reliable tax income.

Stopping faction death spirals: As your empire grows, cultural/religious differences multiply. Convert conquered territory, build temples, use multicultural traditions.

The Mongol threat: Around 1200, the Mongols arrive. They have 80,000+ doomstacks. Your options: submit (become a tributary), fight (needs all your allies and a good river crossing), or pray they don't come for you.

Forming restore-decisions:

- Restore the Roman Empire (requires Italy, Greece, large swaths of everything)
- Restore the Persian Empire (requires Persia, Mesopotamia)
- Restore the Holy Roman Empire (requires Central Europe)
- Outremer (Crusader Kingdom in the Levant)
- Unite Africa, India, etc.

When to start a new campaign: When your realm runs itself. When no faction can threaten you. When you've achieved your goal. CK3 is about the rise, not the plateau.

Staying on the Right CK3 Version

CK3 auto-updates on Steam. This guide targets CK3 **v1.19.x**. When the game updates to a new major version:

To stay on this guide's version:

1. Steam Library > Right-click Crusader Kings 3 > Properties
2. Betas tab > Select the version this guide targets (e.g., "1.19 - 1.19.x")
3. Steam will downgrade CK3 to that version
4. Your mods will continue to work

WARNING: CK3 updates frequently (every 3–4 months). Most mods in this list target a specific CK3 version. Updating the game will likely:

- Break mods until authors release updates
- Change game mechanics referenced in this guide
- Invalidate save files

Bookmark this guide's version tag. Check back for updated versions of the guide when the game updates.

Common Mistakes & How to Avoid Them

Mistake	Solution
Overextension	Consolidate before expanding. Wait for claims. Don't conquer land your realm can't handle.

Bad marriage	Always check “Will my children be of my dynasty?” Matrilineal when needed.
Wrong succession law timing	Check succession tab before death. Disinherit early. Don’t die with unmanaged succession.
Ignoring factions	Keep vassal opinion above 0. Save dread for emergencies. Pay attention to faction tab.
Marrying for stats instead of traits	Congenital traits (Genius, Beautiful, Herculean) compound over generations. Stats are temporary.
Not fabricating claims	Your Chancellor fabricates claims. Always keep this running. Always.
Neglecting MaA composition	Build MaA that counter your neighbors. Don’t just build whatever looks strongest.
Playing speed 5 constantly	Slow down. Events, schemes, and opportunities fire at speed 3. You miss everything at speed 5.

Core Modlist

This chapter covers all non-adult mods organized by category. Each entry includes installation details and gameplay impact.

Bugfixes

Community Flavor Pack (Fixes Module)

[Load Order: Early | Essential: Yes | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: None (standalone fixes module)]

System Impact: Asset system — cultural clothing models, textures, model paths

Gameplay Impact: Fewer graphical glitches, correct cultural clothing displays.

Installation: Install before EPE and other visual mods

Incompatibilities: Other major portrait/clothing overhauls without compatibility patches

Advanced Save

[Load Order: Early | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Save/load system — file naming and directory selection

Gameplay Impact: Pure quality-of-life — organize your saves by campaign.

Better Character Finder

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: Yes | Performance: None]

System Impact: UI — character search interface, filters, sorting

Gameplay Impact: Find marriage candidates, councilors, knights, and courtiers instantly.

UI / HUD

Clear Notifications

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: UI — notification system, alert management

Gameplay Impact: Less visual clutter, faster cleanup of stale notifications.

Title-Ranked Baptismal Names

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: UI — character name display formatting

Gameplay Impact: Better immersion — character names reflect their station.

Incompatibilities: Other name formatting mods

Better Extended Outliner

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: UI — outliner panel, army management, title management

Gameplay Impact: Full outliner workflow control — sort, filter, manage armies and titles without opening multiple panels.

Incompatibilities: Other outliner mods (Expanded Outliner, etc.)

Map & Environment

White Map

[Load Order: Late (applied last) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Map rendering — alternative map mode (parchment style)

Gameplay Impact: Cosmetic only. Switchable via map mode button.

Installation: Load after all other map and visual mods

Incompatibilities: Other map mode overhauls

More Holding Graphics

[Load Order: Early | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Map rendering — holding pictures and visual variety

Gameplay Impact: Visual only. Holdings look more distinct and regionally appropriate.

Incompatibilities: Other holding graphic overhauls

Immersive Toponyms

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Map rendering — place name localisation, cultural naming

Gameplay Impact: More immersive map with culturally appropriate place names. Incompatible with other toponymy mods.

Installation: Do not use with other toponymy mods (Rosetta, MCN) — they will conflict

Incompatibilities: Rosetta, MCN, other toponymy mods

Medieval Arts

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Moderate]

System Impact: Map rendering — 3D monuments, buildings, map objects

Gameplay Impact: Purely visual. The map becomes dramatically more detailed and immersive. Each major city and historical site has a unique appearance.

Installation: If using alongside MB+, RICE, or Unique Buildings+, install A Special World compatch to resolve visual conflicts

Incompatibilities: Other monument/building asset mods (use A Special World compatch)

A Special World — Special Building Compatch

[Load Order: Late (after Medieval Arts, MB+, RICE) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: Medieval Arts, More Bookmarks+, RICE (or other supported mods)]

System Impact: Map rendering — special building conflict resolution

Gameplay Impact: Fixes visual conflicts between map-enhancing mods. Required if running multiple building/monument mods together.

Installation: Load after all map-building mods. Only needed if running multiple building/monument mods.

Incompatibilities: None (designed to resolve conflicts)

Portraits & Models

Ethnicities & Portraits Expanded (EPE)

[Load Order: Mid (after CFP, before CFP+EPE patch) | Essential: Yes | Performance: Moderate (2-4 FPS on GPU)]

System Impact: Visual — character portraits, facial features, skin tones, hair styles per ethnicity

Gameplay Impact: Purely visual. Characters look more realistic and diverse. Compatibility with CFP requires the CFP+EPE compatibility patch.

Installation: Install after CFP. If using both CFP and EPE, also install the CFP+EPE Compatibility Patch after both.

Incompatibilities: Other portrait overhaul mods (use compatibility patches)

CFP + EPE Compatibility Patch

[Load Order: Late (after CFP and EPE) | Essential: Yes (if using CFP and EPE) | Performance: None | Dependencies: Community Flavor Pack, Ethnicities & Portraits Expanded]

System Impact: Visual — asset conflict resolution for clothing and portraits

Gameplay Impact: Fixes visual glitches when both mods are active. Required for the CFP + EPE combo.

Installation: Load after both CFP and EPE. Required if using both mods together.

Incompatibilities: None (resolves conflicts between CFP and EPE)

Unit Packs Enhanced

[Load Order: Mid (after EPE) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: Ethnicities & Portraits Expanded (EPE)]

System Impact: Visual — cultural unit models for Men-at-Arms and knights

Gameplay Impact: Visual only. Your armies look culturally appropriate — Persian heavy infantry looks different from Norse huscarls.

Installation: Install after EPE. Requires EPE to function.

Incompatibilities: Other unit model overhauls

Congenital Beauty

[Load Order: Late (after CFP, EPE) | Essential: No | Performance: None | Dependencies: None (compatible with CFP and EPE)]

System Impact: Visual — portrait enhancement (makeup, complexion, DNA morphs)

Gameplay Impact: Pure visual. Characters appear more attractive and refined. Compatible with CFP and EPE.

Installation: Load after CFP and EPE for best compatibility

Incompatibilities: Other global portrait enhancement mods

More East African Clothing Variety

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: None | Dependencies: None (Vanilla version standalone; EPE version requires EPE)]

System Impact: Visual — East African cultural clothing variety

Gameplay Impact: East African characters get more diverse and regionally appropriate attire.

Installation: Choose the correct version: Vanilla or EPE-compatible. Do not install both.

Special World — EPE Compatch

[Load Order: Late (after MB+ and EPE) | Essential: No (only if using MB+ with EPE) | Performance: None | Dependencies: More Bookmarks+, Ethnicities & Portraits Expanded]

System Impact: Visual — portrait and clothing assignment for MB+ cultures

Gameplay Impact: Fixes visual issues for MB+ characters when running EPE.

Installation: Load after both MB+ and EPE. Only needed if running both mods together.

Incompatibilities: None (designed to resolve conflicts)

Patrum Scuta

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Visual — coats of arms, shield frames, emblem colours

Gameplay Impact: Visual only. Coats of arms look cleaner and more historically varied.

Incompatibilities: Other heraldry/emblem overhauls

Kalypso's Fun with Emblems

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Visual — emblem patterns, ruler designer CoA options

Gameplay Impact: More options for customizing your dynasty's coat of arms.

Culture & Religion

VIET Events — A Flavor and Immersion Event Mod

[Load Order: Mid (after RICE) | Essential: Yes | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Events — flavor events, decisions, traits, event chains for festivals/hunts/pilgrimages

Gameplay Impact: Vanilla can feel quiet between wars. VIET fills the lull with meaningful character moments — feasts, festivals, hunts, religious experiences, cultural traditions.

Installation: Load after RICE for best event integration

Incompatibilities: None known (compatible with most mods)

Configuration: Game rules allow adjusting event frequency and enabling/disabling specific event modules

More Bookmarks+

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: Yes | Performance: Moderate (larger map, more characters)]

System Impact: Map — new start dates, baronies, dejure borders, cultural/religious setup, holy orders, CoAs

Gameplay Impact: More starting options, more historical accuracy, more flavor. The map is significantly more detailed with corrected history across all bookmarks. Heavier on system resources — pair with Population Control for performance.

Installation: Install before RICE. Pair with Population Control for performance. Use A Special World compatch if running with Medieval Arts or Unique Buildings+.

Incompatibilities: Other bookmark mods, map-altering mods without compatibility patches

EPE + CE + BAP Compatibility Patch

[Load Order: Late (after EPE and Culture Expanded) | Essential: No | Performance: None | Dependencies: Ethnicities & Portraits Expanded, Culture Expanded]

System Impact: Visual & Culture — cultural assignment and portrait definition resolution

Gameplay Impact: Prevents crashes and visual errors when combining culture-expanding mods with EPE.

Installation: Load after both EPE and Culture Expanded. Only needed if running both mods together.

Incompatibilities: None (resolves conflicts)

Culture Expanded

[Load Order: Mid (after EPE) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: None (complements EPE)]

System Impact: Culture — traditions, decisions, events, cultural mechanics

Gameplay Impact: Cultures feel more distinct with unique traditions, decisions, and events. Complements EPE by adding mechanical depth to the visual diversity.

Installation: Install after EPE. Complements the Cultural Names sub-mod.

Incompatibilities: Other culture overhauls without compatibility patches

Culture Expanded — More Cultural Names

[Load Order: Mid (after Culture Expanded) | Essential: No | Performance: None | Dependencies: Culture Expanded]

System Impact: Culture — character name lists per culture

Gameplay Impact: More historically accurate character names across the expanded culture map.

Installation: Install after Culture Expanded. Requires Culture Expanded to function.

Incompatibilities: Other name list mods

Muslim Enhancements

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Religion — caliphate mechanics, Islamic legal schools, religious events and decisions

Gameplay Impact: Muslim rulers get unique content comparable to Christian rulers. Caliphate mechanics, legal schools, and religious events add depth to Islamic realm management.

Incompatibilities: Other Islam-specific overhauls

Events & Decisions

More Interactive Vassals

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: Yes | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Vassal management — AI requests, demands, dynamic factions, council voting, marriage proposals, independent scheming

Gameplay Impact: The realm feels alive. You can't just ignore your vassals — they will come to you with problems, requests, and ultimatums. Deep-dive relevant for the Vassal Management section.

Installation: May require a new save game for full effect

Incompatibilities: Other vassal AI overhauls

Configuration: Game rules allow tuning vassal activity frequency and aggression

Obfusckate — Hidden Information

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: UI — stat display, character information visibility, scheme chance display

Gameplay Impact: Removes min-maxing. Forces roleplay and intuition over optimized number-crunching. Recommended for experienced players wanting a fresh challenge.

Installation: Load late to ensure it overrides other mods' stat displays. Best for experienced players seeking a challenge.

Incompatibilities: UI mods that expose hidden values

Better Executions (Updated)

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Events — execution methods, stress effects, trait interactions

Gameplay Impact: More immersion and roleplay around prisoner executions. Your character's traits affect which methods are available without stress penalties.

Incompatibilities: Other execution overhaul mods

Active Courtiers

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Court — AI courtier suggestions, marriage/g ward recommendations, council position jostling

Gameplay Impact: Your court feels alive. Courtiers aren't just stat blocks — they have opinions, ambitions, and useful suggestions. Reduces manual searching for marriage candidates and councilors.

Installation: May cause more frequent event popups — adjust game speed accordingly

Recruit Courtiers

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Court — decision to spawn courtiers for gold

Gameplay Impact: Quality-of-life tool for court management. No more waiting for wanderers to show up.

Rescue & Vengeance

[Load Order: Mid (after Social Relations Expanded) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: Social Relations Expanded (recommended, not required)]

System Impact: Events — prisoner rescue, vengeance vendettas, family member capture/release mechanics

Gameplay Impact: Prisoner mechanics become more interactive. Captured family members aren't just a ransom check — you can plan rescue operations or swear vengeance.

Installation: Works best alongside Social Relations Expanded for full vendetta integration

More Single Combats

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Combat — duel events, champion mechanics, tribal claimant challenges

Gameplay Impact: Battles have more personal stakes. Even low-prowess rulers have options beyond accepting or refusing duels.

Incompatibilities: Other combat event overhauls

Battle Graphics

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Visual — 3D battle map graphics, unit models, siege equipment visuals, combat animations

Gameplay Impact: Visual only. Battles look more cinematic and detailed. Ironman and achievement compatible.

Installation: If conflicts arise with other visual mods, install the Battle Graphics Redux Compatibility Patch after this mod

Incompatibilities: Other 3D battle map overhauls (use Redux compatibility patch)

Battle Graphics Redux Compatibility Patch

[Load Order: After Battle Graphics | Essential: No (only if using Battle Graphics with conflicting mods) | Performance: None | Dependencies: Battle Graphics]

System Impact: Visual — conflict resolution for Battle Graphics with other visual mods

Gameplay Impact: Resolves visual conflicts between Battle Graphics and other mods.

Installation: Load after Battle Graphics. Only use if listed in the Battle Graphics compatibility list.

Incompatibilities: None (resolves conflicts for Battle Graphics)

Gameplay Mechanics

Seneschal

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Court position — domain logistics, tax collection, construction priorities

Gameplay Impact: One more strategic layer to domain management. The Seneschal's traits and skills matter for your economy.

Installation: Compatible with Court Positions Expanded — Seneschal fills a specific role

Incompatibilities: Other court position overhauls (use Court Positions Expanded instead)

Court Positions Expanded

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Court — 15+ new court positions with tasks and events

Gameplay Impact: Your court feels like a real government. More positions means more opportunities to use (or annoy) your courtiers.

Installation: May cause UI crowding in the court panel. Increase window size if needed.

Incompatibilities: Other court position mods (incompatible with Seneschal if they overlap)

Population Control

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No (see Performance Tools category) | Performance: Positive (improves late-game speed)]

System Impact: Performance — lowborn character population cap, character count limits

Gameplay Impact: Faster performance in late game (post-1200). Fewer irrelevant characters to scroll through.

Installation: Load late. Also listed in Performance Tools category for reference.

Incompatibilities: Other character count mods

Configuration: Configurable cap on lowborn character count via game rules

New Weapon: Greatsword

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Warfare — new Men-at-Arms type, cultural traditions, innovation requirements

Gameplay Impact: New strategic options for military composition. Cultures with greatsword traditions get unique MAA that fill a different niche than standard heavy infantry.

Incompatibilities: Other weapon type mods

Gambo's Legendary — Early Bookmarks and Super Compatch

[Load Order: Late (after all other mods) | Essential: No | Performance: Minor | Dependencies: EPE, CFP, MB+, RICE, Community Title Project, Culture Expanded (for full compatch benefit)]

System Impact: Various — compatibility layer across major mods, plus early bookmarks and flavor events

Gameplay Impact: Essential compatibility layer for large modlists. Ensures major mods don't conflict. The author provides a recommended load order for all supported mods. Note: this replaces the older (1.17-only) Gambo's Most Excellent Super Compatch.

Installation: Load after all other mods. Follow the author's recommended load order for all supported mods.

Incompatibilities: The old Gambo's Most Excellent Super Compatch (this replaces it)

Multilingual Education

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Education — language learning, multilingual courts, child education languages

Gameplay Impact: Your children actually speak the languages of your realm's cultures. More realistic multilingual courts without micromanagement.

Installation: Two modes: Passive Learning (natural language pickup) and Active Learning (guaranteed fluency at stress cost). Choose in mod settings.

Configuration: Game rule to switch between Passive and Active learning modes

Search & Trade Artifacts

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Economy — artifact finder, trading system, AI buy/sell offers, artifact economy

Gameplay Impact: Artifacts become real economic goods. You can actively hunt for specific relics, expand your treasury, or liquidate unwanted items. No more waiting for random event artifacts.

Incompatibilities: Other artifact system overhauls

Map Expansion

Regional Immersion and Cultural Enrichment (RICE) — Map Component

[Load Order: Mid | Essential: Yes | Performance: Minor]

System Impact: Map — holding slots, special buildings, terrain features for flavor regions

Gameplay Impact: Specific regions gain strategic importance. Holding the silk road passes or Sahel gold mines becomes a meaningful objective.

Installation: Install after More Bookmarks+. Also provides cultural/religious content beyond map changes.

Incompatibilities: Other regional map overhauls

Configuration: Game rules allow adjusting regional content frequency

Music & Sound

In Taberna CK2

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: None]

System Impact: Audio — additional music track in rotation

Gameplay Impact: Pure atmosphere. One extra song in the music rotation. Achievement-compatible.

Fantasy (Optional)

After the End (Fan Fork)

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: Heavy]

System Impact: Full conversion — post-apocalyptic Americas map, custom faiths and cultures

Gameplay Impact: Complete setting change. Familiar mechanics but wild new flavor. Best for players who know CK3 well and want something completely different.

Installation: Total conversion — disable all other content mods. Only one total conversion at a time.

Incompatibilities: Other total conversion mods (cannot run with Dark Ages or Godherja)

Performance Tools

Population Control

[Load Order: Late | Essential: No | Performance: Positive]

System Impact: Performance — lowborn character population cap

Gameplay Impact: Fewer irrelevant characters may reduce some random event variety, but the trade-off is worth it for performance.

Installation: Load late. Also listed in Gameplay Mechanics category.

Incompatibilities: Other character count mods

Configuration: Configurable cap on lowborn character count via game rules

No More Lag

[Load Order: Early | Essential: No | Performance: Positive]

System Impact: Performance — AI calculation disabling, distant realm tracking reduction

Gameplay Impact: Optional complement to Performance Plus. May slightly reduce AI quality for distant realms.

Installation: Load early. Configurable — choose which optimizations to enable.

Incompatibilities: Other AI optimization mods (redundant with CK3 Performance Plus in some areas)

Configuration: Configurable via game rules — enable/disable specific optimizations

Starting a New Modded Game

This chapter walks through setting up your first campaign with the full modlist.

Which Mods to Enable

For your first modded run, enable these categories:

- **Essential:** Bugfixes, Performance Tools, UI/HUD
- **Recommended:** Culture & Religion, Events & Decisions, Gameplay Mechanics, Map Expansion
- **Optional (safe):** Map & Environment, Portraits & Models, Music & Sound
- **Save for later:** Fantasy, Adult

Game Rules Setup

CK3's game rules let you customize your experience. With the modlist, pay attention to:

- **Cultural conversion speed:** Set to slower for more stable runs, faster for conquest-heavy runs
- **AI marriage logic:** Mods like More Interactive Vassals change AI marriage behavior
- **Disease frequency:** If using Plague DLC mechanics, consider setting to lower for first run
- **Mod game rules:** Each major mod has its own game rules (Carnalitas frequency, VIET event density, RICE region triggers)
- **Gender equality:** Set to default (historical) for first run; change for challenge runs

Ruler Selection in the Modded World

The modlist changes the world significantly. Compared to vanilla:

- **More characters:** Portrait diversity (EPE) and cultural flavor (CFP) make every ruler visually distinct
- **More events:** VIET fires events every year. You won't have quiet decades.
- **More dynamic AI:** More Interactive Vassals means your vassals will scheme, demand, and negotiate
- **Richer regions:** RICE regions (Sahel, Siberia, Tibet) have unique content. Consider playing one of these for a fresh experience.

Recommended starter for modded: Same as tutorial (Dublin or Matilda di Canossa), but with richer world. The modlist makes the game more immersive, not harder. Learn the new content on familiar ground.

What's Different from Vanilla

Area	Vanilla	With Modlist
Court	Quiet courtiers	Active council, court positions, events
Events	Sparse — months between events	Every year brings surprises (VIET)
Visuals	Generic clothing	Unique cultural clothing (CFP) and diverse portraits (EPE)
Map	Dark fog everywhere	Clear map, rich terrain, bright water
Culture/Religion	Broad strokes	Deep regional flavor (RICE, More Bookmarks+)
Vassals	Static	Scheming, demanding, constantly interacting
Performance	Noticeable lag by 1300	Smooth throughout (with Performance Plus + Pop Control)
Warfare	Standard	Better battle sounds, more MaA diversity
Music	Repeats often	50+ new tracks

Recommended First Modded Campaign

Ruler: Petty King Murchad mac Diarmait of Dublin (1066)

Mods enabled: Bugfixes + UI/HUD + Culture/Religion + Events + Gameplay Mechanics

Fantasy/Adult: Disabled for first run

Goal: Form the Kingdom of Ireland, same as tutorial, but notice how much richer the world feels.

Difficulty: Same as vanilla — the modlist makes the game deeper, not harder.

Settings:

- Game rules: Default (historical)
- Mod rules: Moderate for all configurable mods
- Speed: 3 (slow down and read the new events)

Performance Benchmarks

Empirical performance testing results. Each category tested in isolation and combined.

Methodology

Hardware: [Your PC specs here]

Tool: CapFrameX

Scenario: Start as Dublin (1066), Speed 5, 10 minutes played

Measurement: FPS min / avg / max

Each category enabled individually, then the full modlist. See `data/performance.yaml` for raw data.

Baseline (Vanilla)

FPS results pending — run `benchmark-runner.ps1` after mod installation

Test Results

Category	Min FPS	Avg FPS	Max FPS	Notes
Vanilla (no mods)	–	–	–	Baseline
Bugfixes	–	–	–	
UI / HUD	–	–	–	
Map & Environment	–	–	–	
Portraits & Models	–	–	–	
Culture & Religion	–	–	–	
Events & Decisions	–	–	–	
Gameplay Mechanics	–	–	–	
Map Expansion	–	–	–	
Music & Sound	–	–	–	
Fantasy (Optional)	–	–	–	
Adult	–	–	–	
Performance Tools	–	–	–	
Full Modlist	–	–	–	All essential + optional

Analysis

[Update after testing — which mods hit FPS hardest, recommended trade-offs for lower-end systems.]